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New York City

3-Day Itinerary

First-time visitor guide

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2026 Edition • Free guide



Your NYC trip at a glance

This itinerary is built for first-time visitors who want to see the iconic highlights without wasting a day. Each day flows geographically south, minimizing backtracking. You will cover Upper Manhattan, Midtown, Lower Manhattan, and Brooklyn in three days.

Transit tip: Tap your contactless Visa, Mastercard, or phone directly at any subway turnstile — \$2.90 per ride, no card needed. Only buy a 7-day unlimited MetroCard (\$34) if you plan 4+ rides per day every day.

Before you go — book these in advance

- **9/11 Memorial:** Free timed-entry pass required. Book at 911memorial.org before you travel — slots fill weeks ahead.
- **MoMA:** Book timed-entry at moma.org. Walk-ins accepted but weekend slots sell out by midday.
- **Top of the Rock:** Book at topoftherocknyc.com — faster entry, sometimes cheaper than door price.
- **Offline maps:** Download Google Maps NYC offline before you fly. Works in the subway with no signal.
- **Broadway (optional):** TKTS booth (Times Square or South Street Seaport) for same-day discounts up to 50% off.

Day 1 — Manhattan Icons

Morning • Central Park

9:00 am	Enter at 72nd St & Central Park West. Walk south to Strawberry Fields, Bow Bridge, and Bethesda Fountain. Allow 1.5–2 hours. Free entry 24/7.
Cost	Free

Midday • Upper West Side brunch

11:30 am	Jacob's Pickles (509 Amsterdam Ave) for Southern comfort food, or Barney Greengrass (541 Amsterdam Ave) for a classic NYC deli. Both a short walk from the park.
Cost	\$15–25

Afternoon • The High Line

1:30 pm	Take the 1 train south to 34th St, walk west to the High Line entrance. Walk the 1.5-mile elevated park south to Gansevoort St. Public art, gardens, Hudson River views.
Cost	Free
Subway	1 train southbound from 72nd St to 34th St–Penn Station

Evening • Brooklyn Bridge at Sunset

5:00 pm	Take the A/C/E to Fulton St. Walk the Brooklyn Bridge pedestrian path (~30 min) to DUMBO. Best light is 30–45 min before sunset.
Cost	Free (bridge). Return: A train from High St–Brooklyn Bridge.

Dinner in DUMBO: Juliana's pizza (1 Front St) or Time Out Market on the waterfront — both a short walk from the bridge landing.

Day 2 — Culture & Midtown

Morning • Museum of Modern Art (MoMA)

10:00 am	Houses Van Gogh's <i>Starry Night</i> , Monet's <i>Water Lilies</i> , Warhol's <i>Campbell's Soup</i> Cans. Book timed-entry at moma.org before arrival. Allow 2–3 hours.
Cost	\$30 adults. NY State residents free Friday 4–8 pm.
Address	11 W 53rd St. Subway: E/M to 5th Ave–53rd St

Midday • Fifth Avenue & Rockefeller Center

1:00 pm	Walk Fifth Ave 53rd to 49th St. Rockefeller Center Art Deco plaza, St Patrick's Cathedral (free entry, 20 min), and the Channel Gardens.
Cost	Free to walk

Afternoon • Top of the Rock

3:00 pm	The 70th-floor deck gives the best view of the Empire State Building and Central Park — impossible from the ESB itself. Book online.
Cost	\$40 adults — topoftherocknyc.com
Tip	1-hour-before-sunset slot: day and night views on one ticket.

Evening • Hell's Kitchen & Broadway

6:30 pm	Dinner on 9th Ave, 44th–56th St — best value restaurants in Midtown, no tourist markup. TKTS booth (47th & Broadway) for same-day Broadway discounts up to 50% off. Opens 3 pm.
Cost	\$20–40 dinner. Broadway via TKTS: \$60–150.

Day 3 — Lower Manhattan & Brooklyn

Morning • Staten Island Ferry

9:00 am	Free ferry from Whitehall Terminal (4 Whitehall St). Unobstructed Statue of Liberty and skyline views from the water. 25 min each way, every 30 min — ride both ways.
Cost	Free, 24/7, 365 days a year
Subway	1 to South Ferry, or R/W to Whitehall St

Midday • 9/11 Memorial & Wall Street

11:00 am	The twin reflecting pools are free but require a timed-entry pass booked in advance at 911memorial.org . One of the most moving outdoor sites in New York.
Cost	Memorial: free (pre-book). Museum: \$33 optional.
Nearby	Wall Street and the Charging Bull at Bowling Green (5-min walk south).

Afternoon • DUMBO & Brooklyn Bridge Park

2:00 pm	Take the A/C to High St–Brooklyn Bridge directly into DUMBO. Brooklyn Bridge Park has sweeping skyline views and a waterfront lawn.
Cost	Free

Evening • Williamsburg

Solo Safety Notes for This Route

These notes apply to the specific venues and routes in this itinerary. They are practical observations, not warnings -- New York City is a welcoming city for solo female travelers.

Do before dark

Central Park (Day 1)

Paths north of 86th St get quiet after dusk. Finish at Bethesda Fountain and exit by 7:30 pm.

Brooklyn Bridge walk (Day 1)

Keep the ~5 pm sunset slot. After dark, take the A train from High St back to Manhattan.

Brooklyn Bridge Park / DUMBO (Day 3)

The waterfront is best in the afternoon. Start heading toward the A/C at High St by 7 pm.

Williamsburg (Day 3 evening)

Bedford Ave and the main strip are lively and well-lit through the evening. If you are out past midnight, rideshare back rather than the solo L train.

Eating solo comfortably

Jacob's Pickles (Day 1 brunch)

Ask for the bar counter. Eliminates the 'table for one' moment and puts you in the middle of the action.

Time Out Market (Day 1 dinner)

Food hall format: pick from 20+ stalls, grab a communal table. Zero solo awkwardness, vibrant waterfront atmosphere.

Hell's Kitchen, 9th Ave (Day 2 dinner)

Walk 46th-52nd St and pick whatever looks good. Aim for spots with bar seating visible from the window.

Smorgasburg (Day 3 - Sat/Sun, May-Oct)

Outdoor market on the Williamsburg waterfront. Standing food and lawn seating -- a natural fit for solo visitors.

Quick reference

Emergency: 911 | Non-emergency (noise, lost property): 311

Share your live location before each day -- Find My or Google Maps works offline.

Subway after 10 pm: wait in the conductor-car zone (look for the yellow strip on the platform edge).

Rideshare: verify driver name, plate, and photo on-screen before getting in.

5:30 pm	L train to Bedford Ave. Best food scene in Brooklyn. For rooftop drinks, The William Vale hotel (111 N 12th St, Wythe Ave) has a public rooftop bar with panoramic views.
Cost	\$25–50 dinner and drinks
Note	Smorgasburg outdoor food market runs Saturdays and Sundays (May–Oct) on the Williamsburg waterfront.

Packing List

Category	What to bring	Notes
Footwear	Broken-in walking shoes	8–12 miles/day incl. DUMBO cobblestones. Never new shoes.
Clothing	Layers + foldable rain jacket	NYC weather changes within a day. Pack rain jacket.
Hydration	Reusable water bottle	NYC tap water is excellent. Refill free at parks and cafes.
Tech	Portable charger (10,000 mAh+)	Navigation and photos drain your phone fast on long days.
Transit	Contactless card or phone	Tap directly at subway turnstile. No MetroCard needed.
Bag	Zipped daypack or crossbody	Keep valuables in an inner zipped pocket, not back pockets.
Health	Blister plasters	Buy before you go — hard to find mid-walk in Manhattan.
Documents	Digital copies: passport, hotel	Email to yourself and screenshot offline.

Budget Breakdown (per person)

Item	Estimate	Notes
Accommodation (3 nights)	\$140–350/night	Budget: Queens/Brooklyn. Mid-range: Midtown adds 20–30%.
Food (3 days)	\$25–90/day	Budget: bodegas and delis for breakfast save \$10–15/day.
Transport	\$34 total	7-day MetroCard or tap contactless at \$2.90/ride.
Activities	\$65–140	Top of Rock \$40, MoMA \$30. Free: park, bridges, ferry, memorial.
Tipping	\$15–50	18–20% at all restaurants. Non-optional in NYC.
Misc	\$25–70	Souvenirs, coffees, carousel, snacks.
3-Day Total	\$600–1,450	Budget to mid-range. Excludes flights and travel insurance.

Prices are 2026 estimates. Hotel rates are 20–30% lower in April–May and Sep–Oct vs summer peak. Book 6–8 weeks ahead for June–August travel.

Ready to plan your NYC trip?

Full guides to every neighborhood, airport transfers, safety tips, free things to do, and the best time to visit — all free.

travelsamericas.com/destination/nyc